

Working with Copilot & Data — Cheat Sheet

Barts Health NHS × La Fosse | Microsoft 365 Data Skills Training | Modules 3 & 4

A quick-reference guide to where data work fits together, how to write good Copilot prompts, when to reach for Copilot (and when not to), and how to check its output before you trust it.

1 The Data Lifecycle

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
Collection	Storage	Access	Cleaning	Analysis	Visualisation	Communication	Action
Gather raw data from source systems	Save to SharePoint or OneDrive	Open & import into Excel Online	Fix errors, blanks & formatting	Formulas, lookups & PivotTables	Charts & insight-led visuals	Slides, reports & stakeholder comms	Decisions & outcomes driven by data

2 The Five-Component Prompt Framework

1. Role	Who you are asking Copilot to be	e.g. "Act as a data analyst reviewing a compliance report..."
2. Context	What the data or document is about	e.g. "This is a monthly mandatory training completion tracker for Barts Health staff..."
3. Task	What you want Copilot to do	e.g. "Summarise the key patterns in completion rates by directorate..."
4. Constraints	Limits on format, length or scope	e.g. "...in no more than three bullet points, avoiding jargon."
5. Output format	How you want the result presented	e.g. "...as a table" or "as a slide title and three supporting bullets"

3 When to Use Copilot — and When Not To

HIGH VALUE

Use Copilot freely — these tasks benefit most from AI assistance.

Drafting emails and reports, summarising long documents, generating formula syntax, reformatting data, rewriting content for a different audience.

HIGH RISK

Use Copilot, but validate rigorously before sharing anything.

Any output containing specific numbers, named individuals, clinical references, or policy statements. Copilot can hallucinate plausible-sounding facts.

LOW VALUE

Do it manually — Copilot adds more friction than it removes.

Short, simple, well-defined tasks with a clear answer, where writing and reviewing a prompt takes longer than doing the work yourself.

4 Copilot Output — Validation Checklist

1	Accuracy	Are all numbers, names, dates and facts correct? Has Copilot invented anything that sounds plausible but cannot be verified?
2	Completeness	Has Copilot captured everything that matters, or has it summarised in a way that omits a significant finding?
3	Tone & Register	Is the language appropriate for the intended audience and purpose?
4	Barts Health Specificity	Does the output reflect the specific context, standards and terminology of Barts Health, or is it generic?
5	Actionability	If the output is a recommendation or communication, is the ask clear and specific?